School of the
ARTS AND ARCHITECTURE : ART

February 5, 2026

As Area Head of Painting and Drawing in the UCLA Department of Art, I am pleased to nominate Gillian Haigh for the Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. In my role, I oversee teaching assistant appointments and regularly review peer and student evaluations across our program. Through this sustained oversight, I can state with confidence that Ms. Haigh demonstrates an exceptional and consistent record of effective teaching grounded in current best practices in art education and a deep commitment to student learning and success.

Ms. Haigh has served as a teaching assistant every quarter at UCLA across both studio and humanities-based courses, including Beginning Drawing, Beginning Painting, Advanced Painting (twice), Advanced Printmaking (twice), and AA10, Arts Encounters: Exploring Arts Literacy in the 21st Century (twice). Across these varied instructional contexts, she has distinguished herself through a remarkable ability to translate complex artistic and theoretical concepts into accessible, engaging instruction. Her excellence was further recognized through her appointment as an instructor in the School of Art's Summer Institute—an opportunity reserved for individuals who demonstrate both pedagogical strength and leadership. In all settings, Gillian approaches teaching with professionalism, thoughtful preparation, and genuine care for students' intellectual and creative development.

A defining feature of Ms. Haigh's teaching is her use of active learning strategies that foster participation and community. She regularly incorporates small-group discussions, shared digital resources, and collaborative presentations, creating multiple entry points for engagement and reducing barriers often associated with large-group instruction. These approaches empower students to take creative risks, learn from one another, and develop confidence in their voices and ideas.

Ms. Haigh is equally committed to inclusive teaching practices that support the success of all students. She is attentive to the diverse backgrounds, experiences, and learning styles students bring into the classroom and adapts her instruction accordingly. Students consistently describe her as approachable, supportive, and generous with her time. I have personally observed her extending well beyond scheduled class hours to provide individualized feedback and mentorship in the studio. Department staff have also remarked on her reliability and collaborative spirit—particularly Ben Evans, who manages the Painting and Drawing facilities. Ms. Haigh cultivates learning environments where students feel respected, encouraged, and capable—an impact that is especially vital in foundational courses where confidence and belonging are essential to student success.

Perhaps most importantly, Gillian Haigh inspires students to move beyond their perceived limitations. She maintains high expectations while offering clear guidance and thoughtful, constructive feedback that supports meaningful growth. As a teaching assistant, she serves as a vital bridge between faculty goals and student perspectives, connecting theory with practice and institutional expectations with lived experience. Her evaluations consistently highlight her

ability to motivate students, clarify course objectives, and challenge students with rigor and care.

For these reasons, Gillian Haigh exemplifies the values of the Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. Her sustained record of effective, inclusive, and inspiring teaching makes her an outstanding candidate for this recognition, and I offer my strongest endorsement.

Respectfully,
Cosmo Whyte



Assistant Professor
Area Head of Painting
Department of Art
UCLA School of Arts and Architecture

Gillian Haigh
https://www.gilliannhaigh.com/
gilliannhaigh@gmail.com

Nominee StatementNominee Statement:

In a critique in a printmaking class, a student hesitated before sharing a reflection about a peer's work, then quietly disclosed that it brought up experiences of gender-based violence. The room went still. I acknowledged the student's courage, guided the class back into discussion without singling them out, and followed up privately to ensure they felt supported and aware of resources. For me, teaching is defined by how we respond when learning becomes vulnerable and deeply human.

Since completing my required TA training, I have taught every quarter at UCLA across studio and humanities-based courses—Beginning Drawing, Beginning Painting, Advanced Painting (twice), Advanced Printmaking (twice), and Arts Encounters (twice). I have also taught as an instructor in the UCLA Visual Arts Department Summer Institute, where I designed and led a drawing course. Teaching is part of my role as a graduate student, but it is also one of the most fulfilling parts of my time at UCLA.

I have developed my teaching practice intentionally through training and reflection. In my first quarter at UCLA, I took ENGCOMP 404: Diversity and Student-Centered Pedagogy. A core practice I bring into every class is establishing community agreements, informed by Brian Arao and Kristi Clemens's "From Safe Spaces to Brave Spaces." My teaching artifacts include a photo of whiteboard notes from a community agreements lesson. Rather than avoiding difficult conversations, this framework supports honest engagement while emphasizing respect, accountability, and shared responsibility—conditions that consistently strengthen dialogue and participation.

Relationship-building is central to my teaching. I make a deliberate effort to get to know students as people by listening carefully and understanding their perspectives. This approach allows me to better support students academically and personally, particularly when circumstances outside the classroom affect their ability to learn. Student SET survey excerpts in my teaching artifacts reflect these priorities.

One example of this commitment involved a student with a mobility disability who experienced a severe flare-up that made attending class difficult. After listening to her concerns, I worked with her to connect with Bruin Access and secure transportation support. I continued to check in throughout the quarter, and we remain in contact more than a year later.

Alongside facilitation and mentorship, I provide sustained technical and professional instruction. I regularly lead material demonstrations, introducing students to tools and processes while emphasizing experimentation and problem-solving. In every course I TA, I also give an artist talk that I revise in response to students' questions—how I make my work, how I navigate failure, and how I developed my voice. I share this intentionally to model reciprocity and equal vulnerability, and I prioritize asking questions over providing answers whenever possible, trusting students to arrive at their own insights.

Gillian Haigh
https://www.gilliannhaigh.com/
gilliannhaigh@gmail.com

This year, I was selected by the course instructors to serve as Head TA for Arts Encounters. I support other TAs, coordinate section pedagogy, and help the team shape weekly activities and discussion approaches, balancing consistency across sections with responsiveness to student needs.

Arts Encounters is a general education course taken largely by STEM students, and for many it is their first time taking creative risks in a university setting. Because students arrive with very different levels of familiarity with critique and studio expectations, I focus on making goals and evaluation criteria transparent. One way I addressed this was by developing a creative assignment rubric for Arts Encounters (included in my teaching artifacts). The rubric responded to repeated questions about grading and gave students clear language for self-assessment and revision, supporting confidence and more equitable evaluation across sections.

Ultimately, my commitment to teaching excellence lies in sustained engagement, inclusive practices, and long-term support for student success. By combining active learning, technical instruction, mentorship, and leadership, I aim to help students develop confidence, critical awareness, and a sense of belonging.

Gillian Haigh
https://www.gilliannhaigh.com/
gilliannhaigh@gmail.com

Teaching Philosophy

I approach teaching as a relational and ethical practice rooted in care, curiosity, and shared responsibility. As a graduate student and teaching assistant, I work closely with students not only as learners, but as people navigating complex lives, pressures, and institutional demands. I understand the classroom as a community rather than a hierarchy, and I strive to create learning environments where students feel seen, respected, and supported—intellectually, creatively, and personally.

One of my core beliefs as a teacher is that learning happens most meaningfully when students feel safe to take risks, ask questions, and speak honestly. I talk to my students as people, not abstractions or audiences, and I try to be transparent about my expectations, values, and limitations. I regularly let students know that I will never ask them to do something I would not be willing to do myself—whether that means engaging with difficult material, sharing ideas publicly, or reflecting critically on their own assumptions. This ethic of reciprocity helps establish trust and models the kind of intellectual vulnerability I hope students will practice.

As a TA, I often occupy a position that is closer to students' day-to-day experiences than that of the primary instructor, and I see this as a strength. It allows me to act as a bridge—between faculty expectations and student concerns, between theory and lived experience, and between academic structures and the realities students bring into the classroom. Supporting students outside the classroom—through conversation, flexibility when possible, or connecting them with resources—is not separate from teaching for me. These forms of support directly affect how students are able to show up for their learning, participate in class, and take intellectual risks.

My teaching philosophy is grounded in student-centered pedagogy and culturally relevant teaching practices. I believe students learn best when their experiences, identities, and prior knowledge are treated as assets rather than obstacles. In discussion sections and small-group settings, I emphasize dialogue over lecture and encourage students to learn from one another. I aim to cultivate a sense of collective investment in the course, where students feel responsible not only for their own learning but for the learning environment we create together.

I am particularly invested in helping students work with theory in ways that feel usable rather than alienating. This matters to me because I remember how often theory was presented as something to master or perform, rather than something that could support my own thinking and making. As a teacher, I frame theory as a tool—one that students can test, question, and adapt in relation to artworks, material processes, and lived experience. This approach helps students build confidence in their ideas and recognize themselves as active participants in critical discourse, rather than outsiders trying to learn the "right" language.

This approach shaped a project I developed while teaching a drawing course through the UCLA Summer Institute. The project focused on drawing and invention, and I wanted students to consider how drawing has historically functioned as a technology that shapes the world, not simply a means of representation. We examined historical and contemporary examples in which

drawing is made to *do* something: ex. diagrams used to develop weapons technologies, botanical illustrations employed in colonial projects of knowledge-gathering, and speculative drawings of underwater cities imagining the effects of climate change. Students were then invited to create their own drawing-based invention or fiction, guided by the question of what they wanted drawing to accomplish. By encouraging students to reflect on their own relationships to representation and material process, the project emphasized that critical interpretation is something they actively produce through making, thinking, and reflection—not something passively received from authority.

Alongside critical and theoretical inquiry, I place strong value on teaching material and technical skills as inseparable from conceptual thinking. I want students to have the tools to communicate their ideas clearly and to understand how material choices, visual language, and process carry meaning—often before anything is articulated in words. Material decisions are never neutral: scale, medium, line, texture, and composition all register values and assumptions for a viewer. By helping students connect *how* something is made to *what* it communicates, I support them in developing a visual language that is intentional, legible, and responsive. This attention to craft builds agency and confidence—students who feel capable materially are more willing to take conceptual risks, revise their work thoughtfully, and articulate their decisions in critique, writing, and collaborative discussion.

Community-building is central to how I structure classroom activities. Small-group discussions, shared documents, and collaborative presentations allow students with different learning styles to participate meaningfully and reduce the pressure often associated with speaking in large groups. As a TA, I am attentive to group dynamics—who speaks, who is quiet, and how power circulates—and I intervene when necessary to ensure discussions remain respectful, inclusive, and generative.

Equity and care shape not only what I teach, but how I assess. When grading or providing feedback, I prioritize clarity, encouragement, and growth. I see feedback as a conversation rather than a verdict, and I aim to communicate that students' efforts and ideas matter. Low-stakes writing, participation-based assessment, and opportunities for revision help reduce anxiety and make academic success more accessible. I want students to understand that uncertainty is not a failure, but a necessary part of learning.

Ultimately, my goal as a teaching assistant is to help students see themselves as capable thinkers, makers, and contributors to cultural discourse. I want students to leave my classroom feeling more confident in their voices and more attentive to the ways art operates within social, political, and institutional systems. Teaching, for me, is not only about delivering content or building skills—it is about fostering relationships, accountability, and mutual respect. By treating students as whole people and the classroom as a shared space, I aim to create learning environments that are rigorous, inclusive, and grounded in care.

Student Feedback Excerpts (Selection)

Clear Goals, Structure, and Preparation

“I always felt thoroughly prepared and encouraged in endeavors.”

“Gillian was very helpful and professional… She always answers my questions clearly and patiently, and she gives practical suggestions that really improve my work. I feel very supported, and I appreciate the time and effort she puts into helping students.”

“Gillian was amazing. She was extremely intentional, and it was clear that she cares a lot about her students. I am grateful for the effort she put into helping us succeed, and the support she provided along the way.”

“TA Haigh was an incredible asset to the class. Her exceptional organizational skills made the class run smoothly and productively.”

Technical Expertise and Hands-On Instruction

“Gillian was super helpful and I felt like I could go to her if I didn't understand something about the printing processes.”

“Remained an active participant and was extremely helpful in developing other students' technique and conceptual ideas.”

“Gillian is the most involved TA I have ever had… often in art classes, TAs aren’t physically assisting artists, only offering verbal feedback.”

“She was always helpful and insightful, and when I was falling behind she worked alongside me to help get my work done.”

“I learned good problem-solving skills from Gillian, and her feedback.”

“Yes, I was able to try new things and challenge my abilities because of what was expected of me.”

Conceptual Support, Critique, and High Standards

“The TA was super nice and engaging. She made sure to talk to every artist about their upcoming assignment and helped brainstorm ideas.”

“She made sure to question why the art we were making mattered and encouraged us to go beyond what we were capable of.”

“I felt encouraged by Gillian and held to a high standard. Gillian takes things seriously and notices small details.”

“Gillian excels as a teaching assistant… particularly grateful for her ability to pose thought-provoking questions and initiate meaningful conversations.”

Active Engagement and Community Building

"Gillian was more than helpful, always creating an inviting environment for students."

"She was extremely welcoming and made an effort to form meaningful connections with students."

"Gillian helps lead conversations and encourages a lot of dialogue between her, the professor, and peers."

"Gillian worked on her prints alongside us and helped us form better community and share ideas."

"She was always very kind to everyone and never made people feel stupid for asking questions."

"Gillian pays a lot of attention to everyone… it has been exciting to learn from her and her experiences."

Equity, Accessibility, and Support Beyond the Classroom

"I am extremely appreciative for how much she helped me during this quarter, as I was struggling with disability accommodations and mobility/pain issues."

"She took active interest and participation in conversations about diversity and different perspectives."

"Also significantly helped me while dealing with UCLA not meeting the standards for providing me accessible accommodations."

"The environment created in the class felt like a space where people were able to make work about and discuss these perspectives."

Additional Comments

"Gillian is one of the best TA's I've had at UCLA… incredibly knowledgeable, kind, and genuinely wanted us to succeed. She gave meaningful critique and brought chocolate to class for everyone!"

"Great TA, would make a great professor as well."

"Gillian excels as a teaching assistant… goes above and beyond by offering additional support and serving as a source of inspiration… grateful for her initiative in organizing the portfolio building workshop… and her ability to pose thought-provoking questions and initiate meaningful conversations."

"Gillian always went above and beyond for us… always showing up and being available for help in any way. She genuinely cares about each students' success."

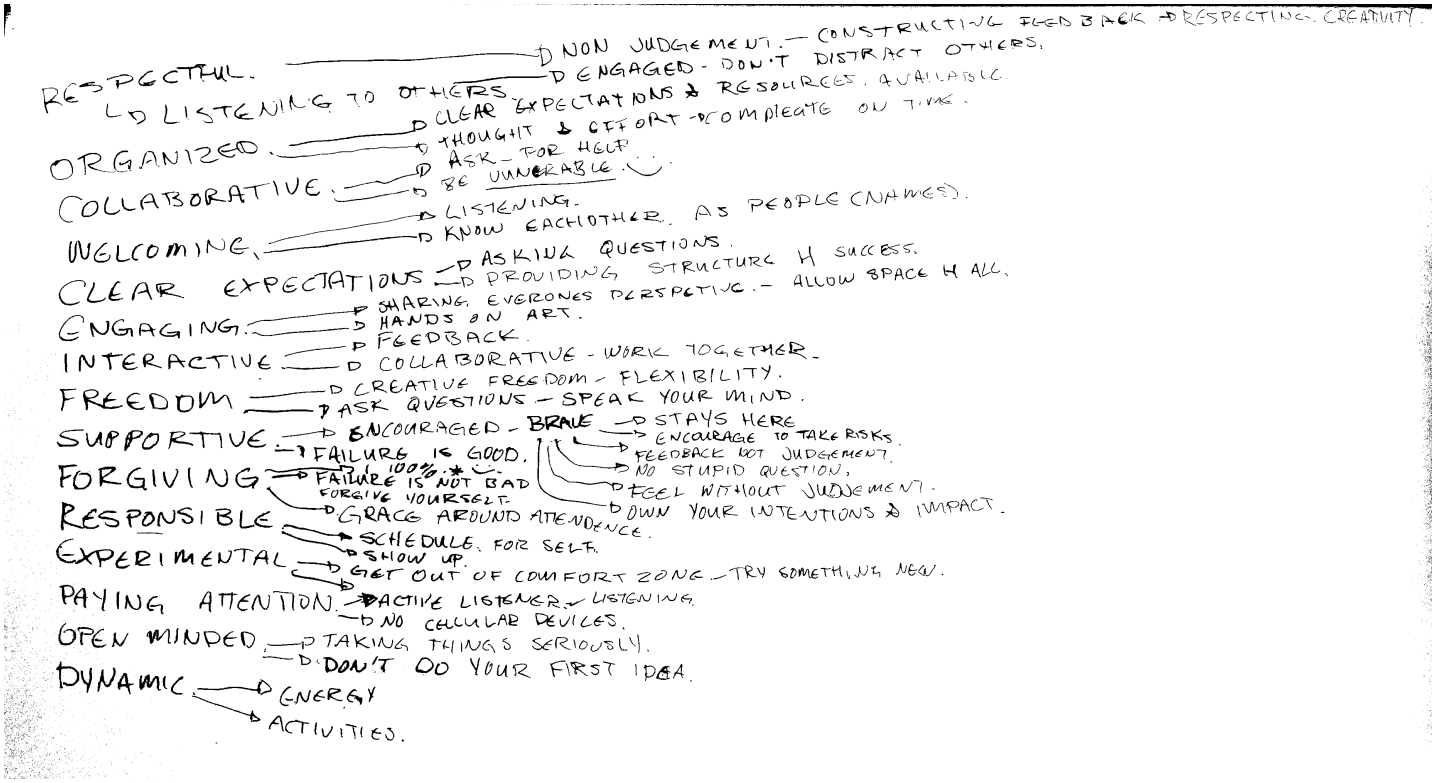
"TA Haigh was an incredible asset… always open to helping. I had several conversations with her about my work, and she was willing to assist me with everything I needed for my grad school application."

Gillian Haigh

Rubric for Creative Assignments AA10 (Arts Encounters). This creative assignment rubric I developed for AA10 (*Arts Encounters*) to clarify expectations and make grading more transparent and equitable for students who are new to and art-making.

Criteria	**Exceeds Expectations**	**Meets Expectations**	**Approaches Expectations**	**Missed Expectations**	**No Credit**
Composition & Use of Visual Strategies	Composition is intentional, engaging, and surprising or thought-provoking. Student makes confident visual choices that support the ideas of the work and invite sustained looking.	Composition is intentional and visually clear. Choices support the overall idea and hold the viewer's attention.	Some intentional choices are evident, but composition feels predictable, unresolved, or underdeveloped.	Visual choices feel unclear, rushed, or unintentional; composition does not effectively support the work.	No evidence of intentional visual decision-making.
Craftsmanship & Care	Work demonstrates a high level of care in construction and material handling. Decisions feel considered and contribute meaningfully to the work.	Work is complete and shows consistent care in execution, with minor issues that do not detract from the overall piece.	Work shows uneven care; some areas feel resolved while others would benefit from more attention or refinement.	Work shows little care in execution; material choices or construction significantly detract from the work.	Work is incomplete or shows no care in construction.
Requirements & Depth	All assignment requirements are met and exceeded. Work shows depth, curiosity, and sustained engagement with the project's ideas.	All major requirements are met. Subject matter is explored clearly and thoughtfully.	Some requirements are missing or only partially addressed; exploration remains surface-level.	Many requirements are missing; work lacks development or clarity.	Requirements not met.
Risk-Taking / Pushing Boundaries	Student pushes beyond their comfort zone, takes meaningful creative risks, or explores an unexpected approach. Work demonstrates experimentation and openness to uncertainty.	Student attempts some risk-taking or experimentation within a familiar framework.	Limited risk-taking; student stays mostly within known or safe approaches.	Work avoids experimentation and relies heavily on predictable or formulaic choices.	No evidence of experimentation or risk-taking.
Originality / Personal Voice	Work is highly original and reflects a strong personal voice or perspective. Influences are transformed through the student's own ideas.	Work is original and shows personal decision-making, even when influenced by external references.	Work relies heavily on existing ideas or sources, with limited personal interpretation.	Work closely imitates another source with minimal transformation.	Direct copy of existing work or uncredited source.

Gillian Haigh



Above is a picture of the whiteboard for a community agreement workshop. I structured the activity as a whole-group circle discussion. Going around the circle in one direction, I asked each student to offer a single word that named what they need in order to learn—what they value in a classroom environment, and what helps them feel able to participate. Those responses became the list of key words on the left side of the page (e.g., *respectful, organized, collaborative, welcoming, clear expectations, supportive,* etc.).

Then, going around the circle in the opposite direction, I asked other students to expand on those words by describing what each value looks like in practice. This second round translated abstract principles into concrete classroom behaviours and shared expectations—specific actions, habits, and responsibilities that would make a word like “respectful” or “supportive” tangible in the room.

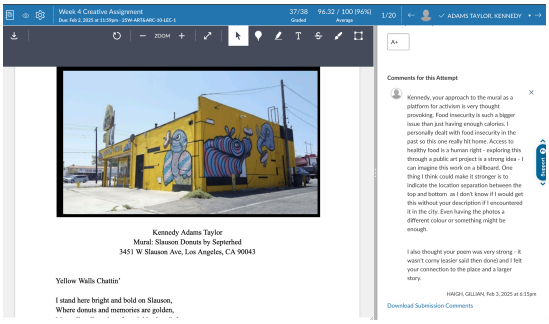
These agreements were not framed as rules for students alone. Some of the expectations also addressed my conduct and responsibilities as the instructor, since I’m part of the classroom community and help shape the conditions for learning. I facilitated the

workshop primarily by asking guiding questions and letting students generate the language and norms themselves, so the final agreement reflects shared ownership rather than a list imposed from above.

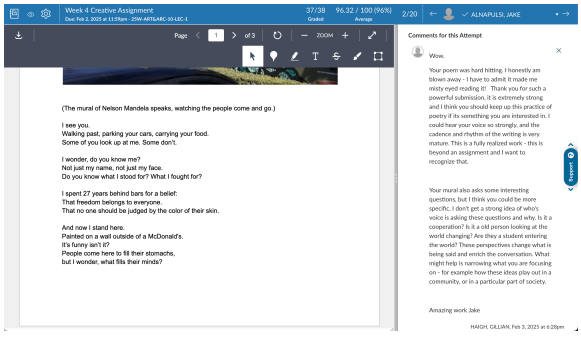
Gillian Haigh

The following excerpts are a selection of my comments from Bruin Learn for AA10 (*Arts Encounters*). All comments come from one assignment (Fall 2025) to give a clear sense of how I engage with students' work in writing. For context, students were asked to choose a mural, write a poem from the mural's perspective, and then propose a mural of their own. Many students—especially those new to art—feel more comfortable opening up online, so I use Bruin Learn as another space for relationship-building and support. In my feedback, I respond closely to the details of their ideas, appreciate their creative effort, and model vulnerability to encourage risk-taking and help students develop their voice.

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"Kennedy, your approach to the mural as a platform for activism is very thought provoking. Food insecurity is such a bigger issue than just having enough calories. I personally dealt with food insecurity in the past so this one really hit home. Access to healthy food is a human right - exploring this through a public art project is a strong idea - I can imagine this work on a billboard. One thing I think could make it stronger is to indicate the location separation between the top and bottom as I don't know if I would get this without your description if I encountered it in the city. Even having the photos a different colour or something might be enough.
I also thought your poem was very strong - it wasn't corny (easier said then done) and I felt your connection to the place and a larger story."



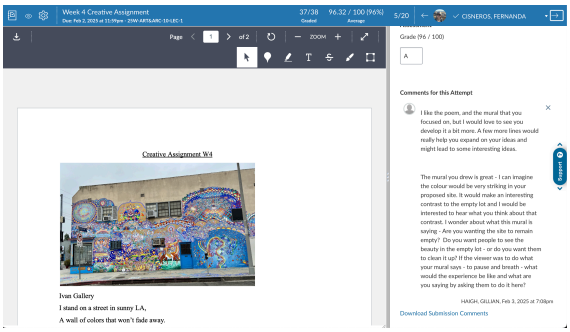
"Wow.

Your poem was hard hitting. I honestly am blown away - I have to admit it made me misty eyed reading it! Thank you for such a powerful submission, it is extremely strong and I think you

should keep up this practice of poetry if its something you are interested in. I could hear your voice so strongly, and the cadence and rhythm of the writing is very mature. This is a fully realized work - this is beyond an assignment and I want to recognize that.

Your mural also asks some interesting questions, but I think you could be more specific. I don't get a strong idea of who's voice is asking these questions and why. Is it a cooperation? Is it a old person looking at the world changing? Are they a student entering the world? These perspectives change what is being said and enrich the conversation. What might help is narrowing what you are focusing on - for example how these ideas play out in a community, or in a particular part of society.

Amazing work Jake"



"I like the poem, and the mural that you focused on, but I would love to see you develop it a bit more. A few more lines would really help you expand on your ideas and might lead to some interesting ideas.

The mural you drew is great - I can imagine the colour would be very striking in your proposed site. It would make an interesting contrast to the empty lot and I would be interested to hear what you think about that contrast. I wonder about what this mural is saying - Are you wanting the site to remain empty? Do you want people to see the beauty in the empty lot - or do you want them to clean it up? If the viewer was to do what your mural says - to pause and breath - what would the experience be like and what are you saying by asking them to do it here?"

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name: Grace Moore

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

Gillian Haigh was my Teaching Assistant in my first Advanced Painting course, during my first fall quarter after transferring. As I adjusted to the university's pace and size, she provided thoughtful support that strengthened my academic performance and fostered my growth within the medium of oil painting.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Gillian approaches her role as a teaching assistant with professionalism, passion, and dedication, offering honest, constructive criticism while uplifting students by recognizing and encouraging their strengths. She creates space for thoughtful dialog and honest feedback. As one of her students, I experienced her expertise in the technical aspects of painting, her deep art historical knowledge, and her ability to push individuals toward their fullest potential. The references she shared, both related to artmaking practices and the conceptual content of my

specific work, challenged me to explore my ideas on a deeper level.

Gillian's passion for her own practice, as well as her commitment to mentoring developing artists, was especially evident during midterm and final critiques, and through dedicated studio visits throughout the quarter. Even after students have completed her course, her investment in their development does not fade. Several quarters later, a fellow student sought her feedback on in-progress and completed paintings, and she generously offered her time and insight. Gillian is an educator whose commitment to her students' success extends beyond the classroom, fostering mentorship that continues outside a formal academic setting.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Gillian approaches each student she mentors with a clear and genuine sense of mutual respect. She confidently embraces her role as both teacher and mentor to developing artists while fostering an educational environment rooted in reciprocal knowledge exchange. The level of professionalism she brings to her position as a teaching assistant made my coursework and artistic expression feel valued and taken seriously. One particularly meaningful example of this was her consistent practice of taking detailed notes during individual critiques. This small but intentional act communicated the depth of care and attention she invests in each student's artistic practice and creative journey.

I was also fortunate to have Gillian as a teaching assistant in the printmaking course, a medium she initially expressed having limited experience with. As the course progressed, we were both able to find our footing within the new techniques. Despite her initial unfamiliarity, she remained fully committed to supporting each student, helping us utilize the processes effectively in service of our conceptual ideas. Her willingness to learn alongside her students demonstrated humility, adaptability, and a deep dedication to our growth as artists.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Another quality is the care and attention she extends to her students beyond the classroom. After experiencing a traumatic injury forcing me to navigate stress, pain, and the complex healthcare system alone, Gillian stepped forward in support. She created space for me to process doctor appointments, the medical system, and continued to encourage my art practice that became impacted by my injury.

Outside the formal responsibilities of a teaching assistant, she recognized that her student was struggling and didn't hesitate to become a compassionate source of support, showing both her dedication as an educator and her character as a person.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Committee
UCLA Department of Art

Re: Letter of Support for Gillian Haigh

I am pleased to write in strong support of Gillian Haigh's nomination for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. I worked with Gillian as the instructor of record for ART 133 (Advanced Painting) in Fall 2024, and I have also known her through the graduate department as a faculty mentor. Across these contexts, Gillian has demonstrated exceptional teaching ability, reliability, and a deep commitment to student learning and well-being.

In ART 133, Gillian played a central role in keeping the course organized and running smoothly. As this was my first time teaching at UCLA, she was a partner in helping me navigate departmental systems and course logistics. Her preparation, follow-through, and calm problem-solving allowed the class to function efficiently while keeping attention on what mattered most: students' work, growth, and engagement.

Gillian's teaching is student-centered and community-driven. Early in the quarter she facilitated a community norms workshop that helped establish shared expectations for critique, discussion, and studio culture. This created a classroom environment where students felt more comfortable taking risks, participating honestly, and learning from one another. She also took initiative beyond day-to-day responsibilities by applying for a visiting lecture grant, expanding the learning opportunities available to students and connecting the course to broader conversations in contemporary painting.

Gillian demonstrated a holistic approach to teaching. She consistently made time to speak with students individually about their work and development, and she was attentive to the realities that shape a student's ability to show up and learn. For example, she supported one student through the graduate school application process by helping them identify programs, sharing her own experiences, and providing feedback on their statements. She also offered support to a student navigating a family loss. In these moments, Gillian balanced empathy with practical guidance, and her presence contributed meaningfully to students' sense of belonging and persistence.

Throughout the quarter, Gillian was also consistently available to me as an instructor. She anticipated needs, communicated clearly, and offered solutions before issues became problems. This combination of pedagogical care and professional reliability made her an effective teaching assistant and collaborator.

Finally, Gillian has been thoughtful about her development as an educator. She has expressed a genuine desire to teach, and I have encouraged her to pursue that path; this award would help recognize the strength of her teaching practice and leadership.

For these reasons, I offer my strongest endorsement of Gillian Haigh for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Sincerely,
Elliott Hundley

Sessional Faculty, UCLA Department of Art
elliotthundley@gmail.com
(310) 433-6014